

A prayer for, and how to pursue Wisdom

Wisdom 9:1-5 A letter from Priest Seraphim. Jan 19/ Feb 1, 2023. St Macarius the Great

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An excellent prayer for Wisdom, who is none other than Jesus Christ, and what we must do to obtain Wisdom.

"O God of my fathers, and Lord of mercy, who hast made all things with thy word, 2 And ordained man through thy wisdom, that he should have dominion over the creatures which thou hast made, 3 And order the world according to equity and righteousness, and execute judgment with an upright heart: 4 Give me wisdom, that sitteth by thy throne; and reject me not from among thy children: 5 For I thy servant and son of thine handmaid am a feeble person, and of a short time, and too young for the understanding of judgment and laws." Wisdom 9:1-5

The scripture is full of prayers and passages that can easily become a prayer. Above is a prayer from the Wisdom of Solomon, for wisdom. It would be excellent to say this prayer occasionally, with a prostration.

This prayer is in keeping with the phronema of the New Testament, which illumines, clarifies, and fulfills the old. It is commanded that we pray for Wisdom: "If any of you lack wisdom, let him ask of God, that giveth to all *men* liberally, and upbraideth not; and it shall be given him." (James 1:5)

As an aside, we absolutely, positively must be regularly reading the Wisdom books. An Orthodox prayer life is not complete without the daily reading of the Psalter, and regular reading of the wisdom books of the Bible such as the Wisdom of Solomon, Sirach, Proverbs, and others. I know that it is hard to establish a daily reading routine. It's hard for some of us even to read weekly. But we must try! As I've gotten older, I've gotten better at this. You can too.

When we are asking for Wisdom, we are asking for Jesus Christ. He is Wisdom, and for us to have Wisdom, He must abide in our heart.

Of course, we think of Wisdom as an attribute of the soul, a part of our personality, and a virtue. And of

course, it is, but we cannot have Wisdom without having Christ abiding in our soul. The prayer asks for Wisdom and then specifies that this Wisdom sits by the throne of God. This Wisdom is none other than Jesus Christ. We are nothing without Him. If He does not abide in our heart, we are nothing.

Indeed, the heart is deep, and God shall be exalted. And our deep heart is capable of containing Wisdom because God has made us capable of containing Him through baptism.

The great mystery of the universe is that God is. A second mystery is that God became man, and because of this mystery, God, who created the entire universe and is bigger than it, can be contained within our deep heart. In a practical sense, perhaps this is the deepest mystery of all.

Of course, when we are asking for Wisdom, that is, asking for Christ to abide in our hearts, we are also promising that we will be attempting to empty our hearts of all of the dross and garbage and passions and darkness. If we do not make this attempt, God will not fully abide in us. We are not capable of doing this work on our own, but we must try. If we do not try, that is, if we do not live a life of active repentance, we are nothing, and we have no Wisdom.

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